

Polity Revision Note: Historical Background

From Company rule to the Constitution: the colonial steps that shaped Indian polity

One-line core idea: British-era reforms were never fully democratic; they first created control, then limited representation, and finally became the template that Indian leaders converted into a sovereign Constitution.

Chronology at a glance	Why it matters
1773 Regulating Act	First parliamentary control over the Company; Governor-General of Bengal; Supreme Court at Calcutta.
1784 Pitt's India Act	Dual control: Company + Board of Control. This is not dyarchy.
1833 Charter Act	Company lost commercial role; administration and lawmaking became more centralised.
1858 Government of India Act	Crown rule begins after 1857; Secretary of State for India replaces Company control.
1861 Indian Councils Act	Legislative councils revived; portfolio system; Indians nominated to councils.
1892 Indian Councils Act	Indirect election begins in a limited form; councils expanded further.
1909 Morley-Minto Reforms	Separate electorates for Muslims; enlarged councils; communal representation deepened.
1919 Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms	Dyarchy in provinces; bicameral legislature at the Centre; franchise widened.
1935 Government of India Act	Provincial autonomy, federal scheme, three lists, RBI, Federal Court. Main colonial template for the Constitution.
1947 Indian Independence Act	Power transferred; India and Pakistan created; Constituent Assembly became sovereign.

Prelims traps to avoid

- 1784 = dual control, not dyarchy.
- 1909 = separate electorates; 1919 = dyarchy.
- 1935 = provincial autonomy and federal scheme, but not a complete federation.
- 1858 = Crown rule begins; it is a transfer of power, not a democratic reform.

Mains angles + memory hook

- Reforms were designed to secure colonial control, not popular sovereignty.
- Explain the continuity from colonial centralisation to constitutional federalism.
- 1935 Act influenced governor's office, emergency powers, PSCs, judiciary, and lists.
- Memory hook: Control - Dual Control - Crown - Electorates - Dyarchy - Autonomy - Freedom.

Must-revise facts:

1773 first parliamentary control | 1858 Crown rule | 1909 separate electorates | 1919 dyarchy | 1935 provincial autonomy | 1947 transfer of power.

30-second recall: Write the three biggest turning points from memory: _____ | _____ | _____.